

THE 48 LAWS OF POWER

ROBERT GREENE

The Big “So What”



Power is an integral part of our societies and lives. This book distills 3,000 years of history into 48 laws that help us to **understand the rules of power, how we can masterfully acquire power and avoid being crushed by others.**

Introduction



No one likes being powerless, yet we don't take well to power-hungry people due to our modern ideologies of fairness, equity etc. It's important to realize that **power is amoral—it's neither good nor evil. You can choose how to use power once you have it, but it'd be foolish to dismiss power as bad or unimportant.** In fact, there's much that we can learn from the masterful scheming of the aristocratic courts of the past—those who can subtly charm, deceive and manipulate without others' awareness can rise to power without others' resentment or resistance.

Green encourages us to think of power-play as a game. **You can use this book to learn about power in general, or study and reflect deeply upon the ideas to truly understand people and the world you live in.**

- Don't judge people by their declared intentions, but the actual outcomes of their actions. People who claim to reject power due to moral values are often the true manipulators (or are simply naïve).
- To master the game of power, you must fundamentally shift your perspective, learn and practice new skills including the ability to master your emotions (so they won't cloud your judgment),

KEY QUOTES

“If the world is like a giant scheming court and we are trapped inside it, there is no use in trying to opt out of the game.”

“Today we face a peculiarly similar paradox to that of the courtier: Everything must appear civilized, decent, democratic, and fair. But if we play by those rules too strictly...we are crushed by those around us how are not so foolish.”

“Those who make a show or display of innocence are the least innocent of all.”

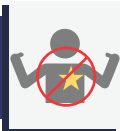
“If deception is the most potent weapon in your arsenal, then patience in all things is your crucial shield.”

objectively examine the past and future (to learn and identify problems) and accept deception and masquerade as a part of human interaction (not something immoral or ugly).

The 48 Laws of Power



Law 1: Never outshine the master



- In your quest to impress the people above you, don't flaunt your talents too much. If your superiors feel insecure, they'll find ways to replace you. Even if you're currently in favor, don't take it for granted as the tides can easily change if you make the wrong moves.
- Instead, make those above you seem superior and smarter than you, e.g. ask for their help and attribute your ideas to their great advice. Give them the limelight rather than outshine them.

Law 2: Don't over-trust friends. Use enemies



- Don't hire your friends for familiarity or as a favor. Friends are more likely to envy and betray you, and also limit your power since it's harder to keep a professional distance. It's better to hire people with the skills and competencies to advance your interests.
- In fact, your enemies can be more useful; use them to create a sense of danger or rally people to your cause. If you can win over a former enemy, he's also likely to be more loyal than a friend.

Law 3: Mask your intentions



- Many people are open books: they can't control what they say or mistakenly believe that honesty can win hearts. It's better to retain the upper hand by hiding your goal till you're ready to strike.

KEY QUOTES

"Make your masters appear more brilliant than you are and you will attain the heights of power."

"Keep friends for friendship, but work with the skilled and competent."

"Honesty is actually a blunt instrument, which bloodies more than it cuts."

- Here are 2 effective tactics to conceal your true purpose:
 - o Throw people off the scent by pretending to support an idea or position that's opposed to your true interest. Or, share a heartfelt thought on something unimportant—people will mistake your sincerity for honesty and believe you when you lie later on.
 - o Distract and misdirect people with a smoke screen. Show them something they're familiar with so they'll let down their guard and be led in the direction you want them to go, without realizing your true intent. Combine this with other smoke screens e.g. a poker-face, noble gesture, or setting a pattern (then breaking it unexpectedly).

Law 4: Always say less than necessary



- The more you say, the less impressive and in-control you seem to be and the higher the chance that you'd say something foolish.
- Powerful people tend to say little. This makes them impressive and intimidating; people can't guess what they're thinking and hang on to their every word and reaction. Short answers and silences also put people on the defensive; when they try to fill the silence by talking, they give away useful information.

Law 5: Protect your reputation at all cost



- Your reputation is like your calling card. It's the foundation of your power. If you're known to be honest, it's easy to get away with deception; if you're known to be ruthless, people will be afraid to cross you. If your reputation is damaged, you'll become vulnerable; seek to elevate yourself by associating with people with the desired image.
- You can also destroy your enemies by hurting their reputation. Once that's done, don't attack them directly; let the public do the work.

KEY QUOTES

"The best deceivers...cultivate an air of honesty in one area to disguise their dishonesty in others. Honesty is merely another decoy in their arsenal of weapons."

"If you lead the sucker down a familiar path, he won't catch on when you lead him into a trap."

"A person who cannot control his words shows that he cannot control himself, and is unworthy of respect."

"Reputation is a treasure to be carefully collected and hoarded."

Law 6: Be conspicuous. Stand out.



- Everything is judged by appearance, and you are inconsequential if you're unseen. Become an attention-magnet by seeming larger-than-life, more colorful or mysterious than others.
 - A good way to gain attention is to make yourself notorious: surround yourself with scandals or sensational people. Bad publicity is still publicity.
 - You can also create an air of mystery around yourself to draw attention and anticipation. It stimulates people's imagination and makes you seem more intriguing and powerful.
- Initially, to rise to power, you must seek attention at all cost. Once you're in the limelight, you must constantly adapt—keep people guessing by acting in unexpected ways, and learn when to pull back so you don't seem desperate for attention.

Law 7: Get others to do the work & take the credit



- This law has 2 parts: (a) don't let others ride on your hard work or steal your credit, and (b) tap on others' work (wisdom, knowledge, effort) to save your own time/energy and build your power base.
 - In reality, the world is made up of hunters vs prey. You won't go far if you try to do all the work yourself or let others take advantage of you. Become the hunter instead.
 - You can also build on others' past achievements, e.g. Shakespeare built his plots, characterization etc. from other writers' works.
- A note of caution: If your power is still not established, don't try to take credit for others' work lest you seem dishonest. Only take credit for the work of those *below* you, but give credit to those *above* you.

KEY QUOTES

"Better to be slandered and attacked than ignored."

"The mysterious cannot be grasped. And what cannot be seized and consumed creates power."

"Never do yourself what others can do for you."

Law 8: Make people come to you



- Stay in control by getting your enemies to respond on your terms.
 - Bait your enemies with attractive gains or provoke them to anger, then attack on your terms/turf. For meetings and negotiations, always lure people to your territory.
 - When people respond to your moves, they'll be abandoning their plans while you hold the cards and stay in control. To succeed, you must master your own emotions while you push/bait others into getting angry or impulsive.
- However, if your enemies are already cornered with nowhere to run, you may consider pressing your advantage to strike where they are.

Law 9: Win through actions, not argument



You can never win through a verbal argument. Such “victories” are temporary at best as people stay resentful beneath the surface. Instead, use actions to *indirectly demonstrate* that your ideas are correct. That way, you can prove your point without offending anyone.

Law 10: Don't get infected by misery & misfortune



Feelings of misery and helplessness are infectious, and people who're drowning can drag others down with them. It's ok to help those who've fallen temporarily due to circumstances beyond their control, but stay away from people who have brought misfortune or unhappiness on themselves due to their toxic attitudes. Instead, associate with happy, positive and successful people.

KEY QUOTES

“When you force the other person to act, you are the one in control.”

“Demonstrate, do not explicate.”

“Emotional states are as infectious as disease.”

Law 11: Make yourself indispensable



- Make people depend on you for their prosperity, success and/or happiness. The more they want and need you, the greater your power and freedom.
 - You may seem indispensable due to your unique skills/talent. Never teach others so much that they can do without you.
 - People may also find it hard to cut you off because your fates are too closely intertwined or if you know their secrets. Unfortunately, this means that you are to some extent also dependent on others. This is the price to pay for power.

Law 12: Disarm with strategic honesty & generosity



- No matter how tough or cynical someone is, you can distract and disarm him/her with carefully-timed acts of honesty, generosity or kindness.
 - Use selective honesty to bring down people's guard, then manipulate them later. This is most effective at your first meeting when first impressions are formed.
 - You can also disarm others with selective generosity, e.g. a seemingly-selfless act, a generous gift, or a calculated act of kindness which touches their hearts and earns their trust.
- This will only work if your gestures seem real and sincere. If you have a bad reputation, flip this law around by playing the rogue, e.g. appearing to have selfish reasons for your actions so people will believe you are acting authentically.

Law 13: Appeal to self-interest, not virtue



- When seeking help or an alliance, focus on the other party's interests and everyday realities rather than noble causes or your own interests. You can also play on their desire to feel superior to you or be publicly seen for their generous contributions.

KEY QUOTES

"Necessity rules the world...If you create no need for yourself, then you will be done away with at first opportunity."

"Better to have others depend on you out of fear of the consequences of losing you than out of love of your company."

"Open-hearted gestures of honesty and generosity bring down the guard of even the most suspicious people."

"A gift is the perfect object in which to hide a deceptive move."

"When people choose between talk about the past and talk about the future, a pragmatic person will always opt for the future and forget the past."

- Don't appeal to others' mercy or gratitude. Even if you've helped them in the past, people dislike being reminded of their debts or obligations.

Law 14: Be a spy. Gather intelligence.



- It's invaluable to know how your opponent will move and where you should strike. Get to know your rivals, especially their secrets and hidden intentions.
- You can use spies or gather intelligence personally by posing as a friend. Use every opportunity to probe for information. You can ask casual/indirect questions at social events, pretend to bare your heart so they're also likely to share their secrets, or lay little traps for them to reveal their weaknesses and intentions.

Law 15: Crush your enemy totally



In your rise to power, you will inevitably make enemies. A strong enemy must always be crushed totally—in body and in spirit—or he/she will eventually retaliate. You cannot afford to show mercy or stop halfway. Banish your enemies totally so they won't pose any future threats.

Law 16: Raise your value via absence & scarcity



- When you are too easily available, you seem common. Once you've established yourself, learn to withdraw temporarily from your community, so people will feel your absence and value your presence even more when you return.
- This law only works if you've already attained a certain level of power and presence. Master the art of alternating presence and absence; withdraw just before people start taking you for granted.

KEY QUOTES

"Arm yourself with a little knowledge and your aim improves."

"Give them a false confession and they will give you a real one."

"If one ember is left alight, no matter how dimly it smolders, a fire will eventually break out."

"What withdraws, what becomes scarce, suddenly seems to deserve our respect and honor."

Law 17: Be unpredictable: keep others in suspense



- Humans feel uncomfortable about uncertainty. By being unpredictable, you keep others off-balance as they try to guess your goals and next moves. At the very least, it will stimulate interest and suspense; at an extreme (e.g. if you use deliberate attacks or ambushes) you can even instill fear or terror.
- You can also use predictability to lull others into complacency before you attack or disrupt them.

Law 18: Don't isolate yourself behind a fortress



- When you face uncertainty and danger, resist the temptation to hide behind a fortress to protect yourself. Isolation is dangerous as it cuts you off from valuable information and makes you an easy target.
- It's better to hide yourself in the crowd, build alliances far and wide and have your eyes and ears everywhere.

Law 19: Know who you're dealing with



- To gain and retain power, you must acquire the vital skill of assessing people—know who and what kind of people you're dealing with, so you can work with the right people and avoid offending the wrong ones. If you offend or deceive someone who's extremely insecure, suspicious or calculative, he/she is likely to come after you with a vengeance.
- Don't trust appearances; gather concrete knowledge about your opponents rather than rely on instincts.

KEY QUOTES

"When people cannot figure out what you are doing, they are kept in a state of terror—waiting, uncertain, confused."

"Isolation exposes you to more dangers than it protects you from."

Law 20: Stay independent (for as long as possible)



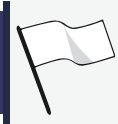
- Show just enough interest for people to think you may be willing to support them, but don't commit to anyone or any cause (except your own). That way, you can be courted by all parties.
- Stay neutral so you're not drawn into petty quarrels. This allows you to play people against one another or to gain power as a mediator.

Law 21: Make your victims feel smarter than you



- People don't like to feel stupider than others. If you appear to be less intelligent or sophisticated than your victims, they won't suspect that you're capable of ulterior motives or outsmarting them.
- The exception is when you want others to believe you. In such cases, it's better to seem smarter than you really are to project authority and knowledge.

Law 22: Use surrender as a tool



If you're obviously in a weaker position, there's no point fighting your opponent directly. Use surrender as a tactic to lull your enemy into complacency. Pretend to be defeated, but take the time to recover, unsettle your enemy and eventually retaliate.

Law 23: Concentrate your forces



Don't spread your resources too thin by fighting multiple battles. Concentrate your power—focus it like the tip of an arrow for the greatest impact. Likewise, it's better to find 1 strong patron with deep pockets to support and elevate you, than to rely on many minor ones.

KEY QUOTES

"To reveal the true nature of your intelligence rarely pays; you should get in the habit of downplaying it at all times."

"This is the essence of the surrender tactic: Inwardly you stay firm, but outwardly you bend."

"Intensity defeats extensity every time."

"Concentrate on a single goal, a single task, and beat it into submission."

Law 24: Be a masterful courtier



A successful courtier knows how to juggle the complex power-play at court. Be modest (not flamboyant), get noticed (without being too brazen), tailor your approach to each opponent, assert power subtly, flatter indirectly, be observant, master your emotions, and be a source of pleasure and good news.

Law 25: Create your own identity



- Break free from the roles and expectations imposed by society. If you don't define your own image, others will do it for you.
- Create identities to suit different roles and treat them like costumes that you can change. Keep your identity interesting. Incorporate drama (e.g. surprise, suspense, sympathy and symbols) to gain attention and make yourself seem larger than life.

Law 26: Don't dirty your hands



Have a convenient scapegoat (ideally someone innocent and powerless) to take the blame for mistakes. Get someone else do the nasty work (e.g. be the executioner or announce bad news) so you're only associated with positive news and events.

Law 27: Create a cult-like following



- Humans *need* to believe in something bigger than themselves. If you give them the right focal point, they'll follow you religiously.
- To create a cult, use vague but promising words that help people to dream and see what they *want* to see, focus on sensations and visuals, create rituals/hierarchies and ask for sacrifices that'll enrich you. Show symbols of wealth, but hide the fact that your wealth comes from your followers. Identify/invent an external enemy so you can use "us-vs-them" to rally people around you.

KEY QUOTES

"Courtiers are like magicians: They deceptively play with appearances, only letting those around them see what they want them to see."

"The first step in the process of self-creation is self-consciousness—being aware of yourself as an actor and taking control of your appearance and emotions."

"Our good name and reputation depend more on what we conceal than on what we reveal."

Law 28: Act with boldness



- When people perceive you to be bold, they're more likely to believe you, overcome their own doubts and give in to your requests.
- Timidity produces the opposite effects. If you are unsure about a decision, don't proceed as others will sense your doubts.
- Both boldness and timidity are acquired habits, i.e. they can be learned. Plan ahead so you can take bold actions at the right time.

Law 29: Plan till the end



Consider all possible outcomes and obstacles, so you're prepared to deal with unforeseen circumstances and know when to stop/change the plan. The key is to gain clarity and be confident about adapting to changing circumstances, not to be tied down by over-planning.

Law 30: Make your achievements seem effortless



- Research and practise repeatedly behind the scenes before you show your work publicly, so you seem to achieve the results effortlessly.
- Don't show the tricks or hard work behind your results—it will demystify you and allow other to copy what you do. It's ok to show *part* of your tricks/techniques so long as you maintain the illusion of superiority.

Law 31: Control the options



- The best way to manipulate people is to give them the perception that they're making a choice. In reality, you're the one dealing the cards and whichever option they choose would be in your favor.

KEY QUOTES

"Everyone admires the bold; no one honors the timid."

"Gently guide fortune and help determine the future by thinking far ahead."

"One never sees the source of a god's power revealed; one only sees its effect."

- Some common tactics include: present a few options and make your preferred option look clearly better, force them to choose between the lesser of two evils, or raise the price each time the buyer delays making a decision (until they dare not delay further).

Law 32: Play to people's fantasies



- People prefer to believe in fantasies, like a windfall or a sudden rise to success, rather than face the harsh realities of hard work, learning from mistakes or gradual change.
- An effective fantasy should be like a mirage in the distance—clear enough to be tempting but vague/far enough that they have to keep desiring and reaching for it.

Law 33: Find your opponent's fatal weakness



To penetrate someone's defences, you must identify their fatal weakness: this may be in the form of an insecurity, an uncontrollable emotion/need or a secret desire. Look out for subtle cues in your interactions, triggers that make them react like a child, and prod for the source of their insecurity, unhappiness, or fear.

Law 34: Act in the way you want to be treated



The way you carry yourself affects how people respond to you. Adopt the "Strategy of the Crown", i.e. act like a king (regal and confident, but not arrogant) so you'll be treated like one. Make bold demands without wavering, approach the highest person in the hierarchy with dignity, or give a gift to someone above you as if you're equals.

Law 35: Master the art of timing



Never seem to be in a hurry; learn to hold back until the time is ripe, then strike decisively to reach a swift conclusion. To grasp the right timing, you must (a) be able think long-term so you can see

KEY QUOTES

"Life is so harsh and distressing that people who can manufacture romance or conjure up fantasy are like oases in the desert: Everyone flocks to them."

"How you carry yourself reflects what you think of yourself."

"Learn to stand back when the time is not yet ripe, and to strike fiercely when it has reached fruition."

the big picture and be patient, (b) be able to use forced timelines to make others wait, hurry, or lose their sense of time and (c) time your actions so you bring things to an end at a strategic time.

Law 36: Ignore what you can't have



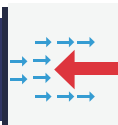
- Don't allow petty issues to bother you. When you pay attention to a problem or person, you give it credibility and power. When you want something desperately, you become weak. The less interest you show, the more power you retain.
- If there's something you want but cannot have (and it won't hurt you in the long-term), it's best to show disinterest or even contempt for it. If you're being attacked by someone inferior, ignore them to show you're unconcerned or unaffected.

Law 37: Dazzle people with spectacles



Use compelling visuals and powerful symbols and associations (e.g. linking yourself with famous people or events) that make you larger than life and amplify your aura of power. When people are so overwhelmed by appearances and what you seem to represent, they'll overlook what you are really doing.

Law 38: Hide your unorthodox thinking



- Don't flaunt your unconventional ideas—especially if they involve strongly-held beliefs and values—as people may think you're seeking attention or putting them down.
- Instead, pretend to be like others. Share your radical ideas only with your inner circle who can appreciate your uniqueness, and use indirect ways to publicize these ideas (e.g. pretend to argue against the radical ideas but use the chance to expose them).

KEY QUOTES

"Learn to play the card of disdain and turn our back on what cannot harm you in the long term."

"People love what is grand, spectacular, and larger than life. Appeal to their emotions and they will flock to your spectacle in hordes."

Law 39: Stir up waters to catch the fish



If you lose your temper or control, you lose your followers' respect and confidence. However, if you can make your enemies angry while you stay calm, you gain a huge advantage. Play on your opponents' pride, love, hate, or vanity—throw them off-balance so they'll act recklessly and give you the chance to crush them.

Law 40: Beware the free lunch



- Don't trust what's offered for free or a bargain—it usually means lower quality or a psychological price tag, e.g. feelings of obligation or guilt which lead to compromises later.
- If something has real value, pay for it so you avoid the traps and deceit. Build a reputation of being generous and use strategic gifts/spending to increase your influence and power.

Law 41: Don't try to fill a great man's shoes



When you step into a great man's shoes, you'll have to achieve *much* more to outshine them. The best way to avoid being lost in your predecessor's shadow is to chart a new course and establish your own name with your own style, symbols and rituals. You don't need to start from ground zero; simply play down the past and amplify the differences of the present times. Gain power by shining in your own way.

Law 42: Strike the shepherd to scatter the sheep



- Trouble in a group can usually be traced to a single person who's stirring up dissent and anxiety. Left unchecked, the negative vibes will spread until it's too late.
- Strike at the source of the problem by removing the person (physically, politically or psychologically) to stop his/her toxic influence. Such isolation will also dishearten the person and make him/her vulnerable.

KEY QUOTES

"Stir the waters, force the fish to the surface, get them to act before they are ready, steal the initiative."

"In the realm of power, everything must be judged by its cost, and everything has a price."

"Powerful people give freely, buying influence rather than things."

"Cancer begins with a single cell; excise it before it spreads beyond cure."

Law 43: Win both hearts and minds



A person who is forced to do something will eventually retaliate. To gain power and loyalty, you must make others *want* to do what you desire. Step back to understand the other party's emotional makeup and psychological weakness. Then, soften their resistance: play on their key emotions (love, hate, jealousy) and demonstrate how something will serve their self-interests.

Law 44: Unbalance and confuse with the mirror effect



Mirrors simulate reality. You can use the “Mirror Effect” to throw your enemy off-balance in at least 4 ways:

- Copy their actions while you lay invisible traps, so they're unsettled and can't see what you're up to.
- Find out their deepest desires/values and reflect it back to them so they naturally like you and lower their defences.
- Teach them a lesson by giving them a taste of their own medicine.
- Create an illusion that they mistake for the real thing.

Law 45: Go for gradual change, not drastic reform



People resist change, even if they understand the need for it. Don't push for drastic changes as it could backfire. If you are new to a position or community, start by showing respect for the old ways of doing things, then introduce changes gradually as small improvements, linked to ideas that people already accept.

Law 46: Don't seem too perfect



When you seem to be better than others—or worse, to have no flaws—people get envious and silently resent you. Don't flaunt your

KEY QUOTES

“Ignore the hearts and minds of others and they will grow to hate you.”

“Everyone understands the need for change in the abstract, but on the day-to-day level people are creatures of habit.”

“The fool dares the gods of envy by flaunting his victories.”

wealth, power, superior qualities or victories. Instead, occasionally show that you have harmless vices or minor weaknesses, so you seem more human and approachable.

Law 47: Don't push too far in victory



- When you're victorious, know when to stop. Don't let success get to your head; resist the temptation to push too far beyond your original goal. Arrogance and overconfidence can attract enemies and make you blind to your vulnerabilities.
- Maintain your rhythm of success—plan carefully, stop when you reach your goal, consolidate and plan again before moving forward.

Law 48: Be formless



Your enemies can't attack what they can't see. Learn to adapt, move rapidly and in a non-linear way so your opponents can't grasp what form you will take, nor have the time to respond to your unexpected attacks. Train yourself not to reveal your emotions, don't adopt a fixed strategy/style and don't follow conventional advice.

Other Details in the Book to Look out For



This is packed with stories and examples of court politics, courtship, and warfare involving kings, emperors, nobility and famous people from different countries and cultures from the past. For each of the laws, Greene includes stories and interpretations to illustrate the laws at work, as well as the exceptions to the laws.

KEY QUOTES

"Power has its own rhythms and patterns. Those who succeed at the game are those who control the patterns and vary them at will."

"The best way to protect yourself is to be as fluid and formless as water."